

1 The Facebook platform

The Facebook logo, consisting of the word "facebook" in white lowercase letters on a blue rectangular background.

The Facebook platform consists of various elements that allow application developers to build an application and replicate the look and feel of Facebook within it. These elements are mostly derived from well-known web development languages such as HTML, SQL and JavaScript for easy portability. They are:

The API (Application Programming Interface), also known as the REST API that handles communication and function calls between Facebook and your application.

- FBML (Facebook Markup Language), a markup language derived from HTML
- FQL (Facebook Query Language), for data handling.
- Facebook JavaScript, for scripting needs.
- Client libraries for programming languages.

Let us look at all of these components in detail to understand the need and use of them while making powerful yet simple Facebook applications.

1.1 FBML (Facebook Markup Language)

It is a tag-based programming language like HTML used to format your information, albeit a bit more fancy as each interaction starts and ends with a tag. FBML provides a large set of Facebook user interface and programmatic primitives required to abstract complex code and make most routine procedures effortless. The tags are automatically parsed and translated into HTML, CSS (Cascading Style Sheets), and JavaScript code by Facebook servers when a request for an application page that contains it is detected. If you've previously used HTML, then you will have no problems